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UNTIL LAST YEAR, DHRUV RATHEE WAS CONTENT BEING AN "EDUCATOR" ON YOUTUBE, sharing videos on a variety of subjects that served as "explainers that inspire". Then came an episode that Rathee, much like the Supreme Court of India, saw as a "murder of democracy". It was the widely-circulated video clip of Anil Masih, returning officer for the January 30 Chandigarh mayoral poll, defacing eight ballot papers, resulting in the win of the BJP candidate over his AAP counterpart. Since then, the 29-year-old engineering postgraduate's team, comprising 10-15 researchers and editors, has been rigorously scouring articles and videos for credible data and help Rathee prepare a script that can serve as "explainers that alarm".

It has resulted in videos like '*Dara Hua Dictator*' (Arvind Kejriwal Jailed! Dictatorship Confirmed?), which spread like wildfire on the internet, accumulating 34 million views since its release on April 1. Another called Prime Minister Narendra Modi a "liar" by splicing together footage to highlight the contradictions in election speeches. Rathee's videos, rendered in Hindi, have seen his subscriber base balloon to 20.7 million, 5.7 million in the past three months alone; become a target of Modi supporters who have circulated a fake forward saying he's a Muslim (he is, in fact, a Jat from Haryana currently based in Berlin); and be heralded as the poster boy of the supporters of the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) by addressing issues that they feel mainstream media has ignored. In an interview to INDIA TODAY magazine, Rathee summed up his turn from educator to political commentator as a "service to the nation. The core idea is to save the country's democracy".

Rathee is among a growing tribe of young digital creators who are using social media to shape public opinion, particularly among Gen Z, and influencing the 2024 general election in the process. Giving





